

EDGE RESEARCH REPORT

Tab Central Diary Study



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CONTRIBUTORS

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Approach

We randomly assigned 14 horizontal tab users to the Switcher or Transient experience. On the final day they saw a recording demoing the unassigned version.

Research Questions

How does Tab Central (Switcher & Transient variants) help horizontal tab users navigate tab clutter, discover different tab tools, explore different states?

Method

Day 0
Setup

Implement the flag in
Edge Dev

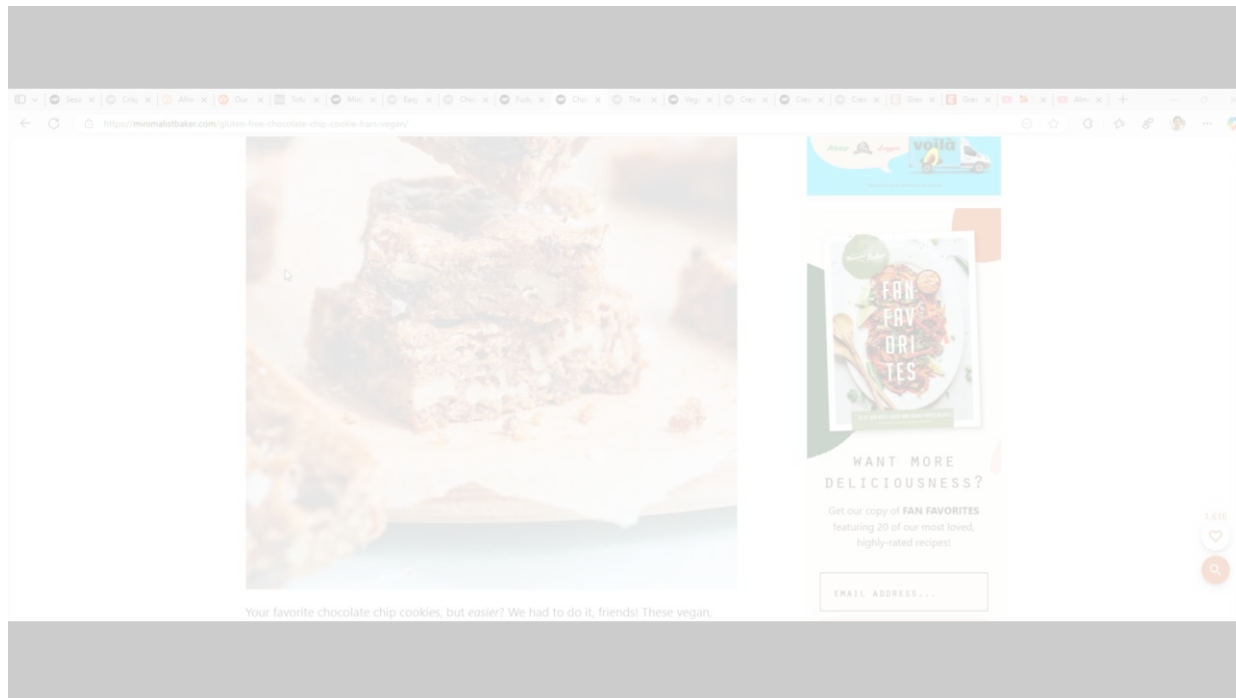
Days 1-6
Diary Study

Measure how satisfaction & usage patterns evolve throughout the week, collect impressions of specific tools & features (Tab search, Workspaces).

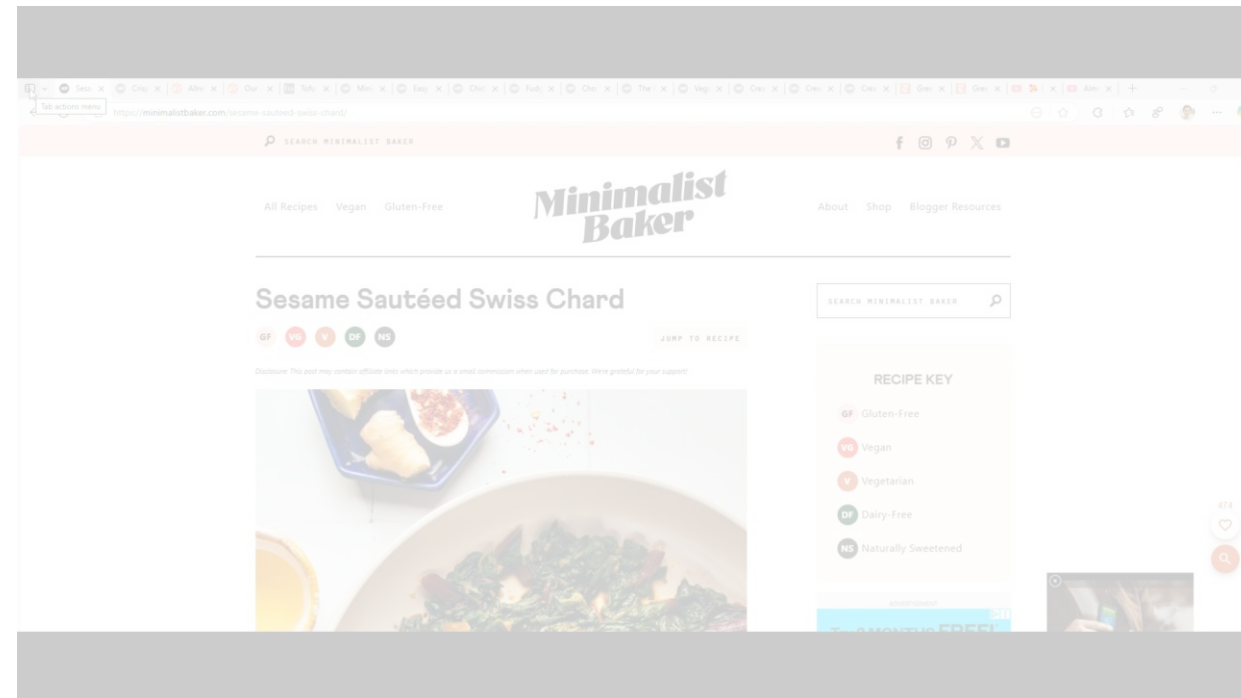
Tab Central versions

Horizontal tab users who have 10+ tabs open on average.

Switcher



Transient



Aligns with our design principles | Designed to reduce the number of states the browser can be in

Potentially more flexible | Horizontal users don't need to change their habits.

Explore now in Edge Dev or Edge Canary using `edge://flags:project-jupiter`

Participants

Horizontal tab users who have 10+ tabs open on average were assigned to either the Switcher or Transient condition

Switcher



Sharon
PhD Applicant



Jen H
Delivery driver



Lauren
Research
Administrator



Jennifer W
Self-employed



Hanson
Master's
Student



Tyvon
Content
Creator



Chidubem
Football
Recruiter

Transient



Naomi
Medical
Student



Allison
College
Student



Janet
Teambuilding
and Personal
Development



Brandon
Field Engineer



Debbie
Chief
Information
Officer



Stephanie
Marketing
Communications
Specialist



Taylor
Graduate
Student



2 participants did not complete the entire diary study and dropped after 1-2 days

Results

Highlight reel

Listen to participants describe how
Tab Central



helps them manage tab clutter,



discover other tools,



explore vertical tabs
(*caveat, more success with
Switcher mode)

**Participants managed
tab clutter**

Switcher performed better than Transient at helping participants explore different states

Not to mention, Switcher wasn't as disorienting as we feared.

Switcher

- ☒ Navigate tab clutter
- ☒ Discover different tab tools
- ☒ Explore different states

Switcher is not the trap we thought it was

About half our participants closed & opened Tab Central only as needed. **0** felt trapped in vertical.

Transient

- ☒ Navigate tab clutter
- ☒ Discover different tab tools
- ☒ Explore different states

We aimed for flexibility but achieved subtlety

Only **2** participants discovered and explored pinned vertical tabs during the study.

Why care about vertical tabs | Right now awareness is low (3-4%). It is in our best interest to introduce more users to it without alienating those who prefer horizontal tabs.

Participants were split between Switcher and Transient

Though we recommend Switcher, we must retain the qualities of Transient mode that people value

Chose Transient



"[Pinned] takes up a lot of real estate on this side."



"it presents the feature in a less in-your-face fashion."



Chose Switcher



"I have no need for the dropdown menu."



"[Switcher] means less clicks for the same results."

Chose Neither



"I do not see vertical tabs being something that I explore any further."

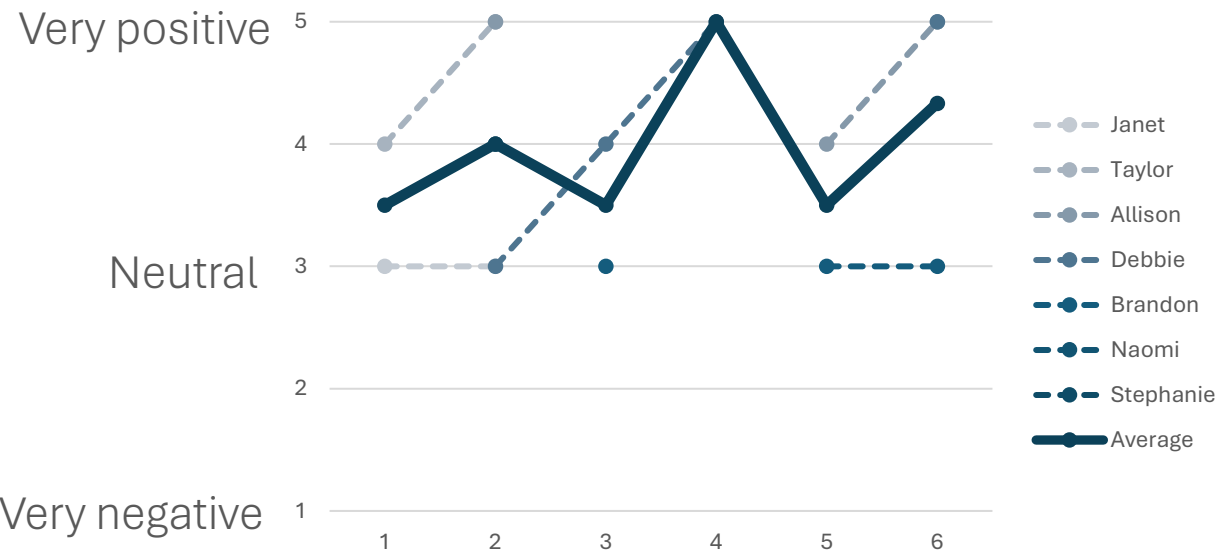
Three participants didn't pick up on the difference

Recommendation | Move ahead with Switcher and ensure it doesn't force users into vertical mode

Impressions of both variants were on average positive (4/5)

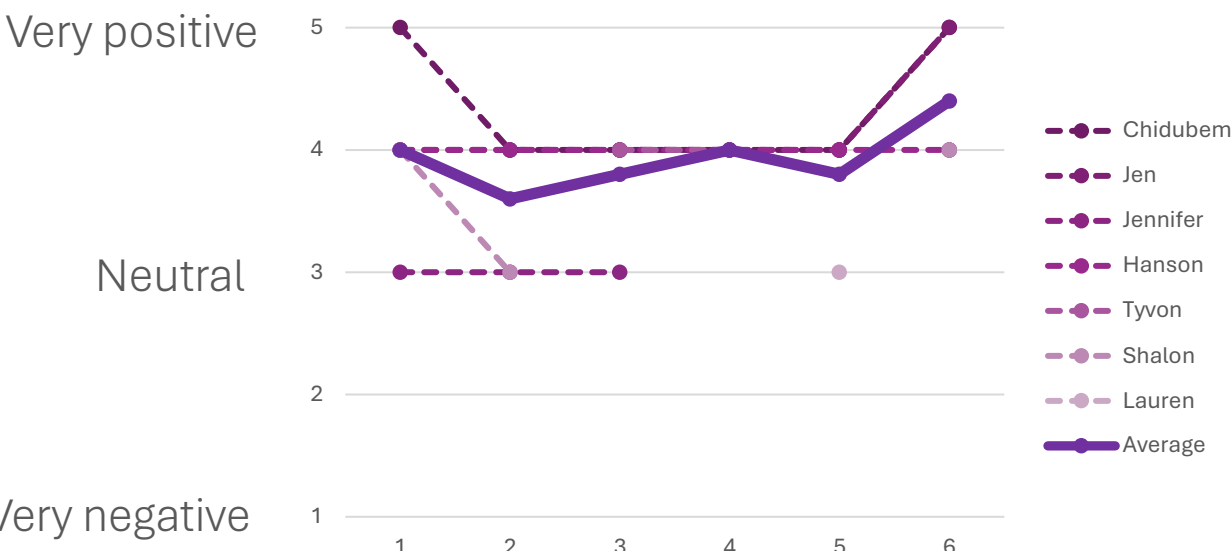
Transient

Used Tab Central **about half** 🧑 of the days (vs. kept it closed)



Switcher

Used Tab Central on average **5/6** days (vs. kept it closed)



🧑 If our dropouts continued, the max this could have been is 4/6 days

Insight | In Switcher mode Tab Central is more available (and therefore more used) but not more frustrating.

Switcher participants who kept tabs in vertical benefitted from it

4 Switcher participants kept their tabs vertical most of the study. They were able to maneuver better and see more of the tab titles.



Jen H, Delivery Driver
Switcher Condition

Day 1
20+ tabs

Day 2
45 tabs

Day 3
47 tabs

Day 4
47 tabs

Day 5
47 tabs

Day 6
30-40 tabs

“I was able to go through my collections and go through [Tab Central], I can leave it open so I can go back to it”

“I feel more organized and its easier to maneuver”

“Now I see almost the whole title... it’s less stressful”



Lauren, Research Admin
Switcher Condition

Day 1
2 tabs

Day 2
6 tabs

Day 3
6 tabs

Day 4
2-3 tabs

Day 5
3 tabs

Day 6
8 tabs

“I guess the vertical tabs are fine”

“When they are vertical it’s easier to scan with your eyes”

“[vertical tabs] is something I will probably take forward with me... before I didn’t see the use”



Days they didn't use the feature

Many participants used Tab Central sparingly

3 Switcher and 5 Transient participants kept their tabs horizontal most of the time. They used the feature as needed.



Allison, College Student

Transient Condition

Day 1

3 tabs

Day 2

10 tabs

Day 3

4 tabs

Day 4

3 tabs

"keeping track of some bills and watching some videos, didn't require a lot of tabs"

Day 5

7 tabs

"It really helped me organize my thoughts for my ungrouped tabs"

Day 6

7 tabs



Shallon, PhD Applicant

Switcher Condition

Day 1

6-8 tabs

"Switching tabs to do research... [Tab Central] is more effective for storing and organizing."

Day 2

10-15 tabs

Day 3

11 tabs

"I worked a 9hr shift today... didn't have time to use it"

Day 4

2-3 tabs

Day 5

5 tabs

Day 6

26 tabs

"I needed to organize around 15+ websites into one group"

Insight | Both Switcher and Transient enable horizontal tab users to use Tab Central to their liking

 Days they didn't use the feature

Some heavy tab users want tabs gone, not managed

3 weren't interested in tab management despite typically having 10+ open tabs.



Janet, Teambuilding Expert
Transient Condition

Day 1
4 tabs

Day 2
4 tabs

Day 3
4 tabs

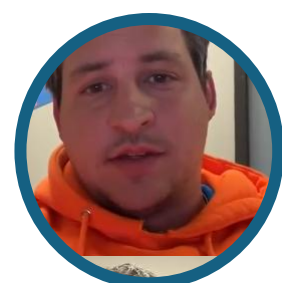
Day 4
20 tabs

Day 5
NA

Day 6
7 tabs

"I don't understand when I would ever want to organize tabs versus just getting rid of them..."

"I just quickly closed them by keeping my mouse in one place and exiting them as they fell under the cursor"



Brandon, Field Engineer
Transient Condition

Day 1
6-8 tabs

Day 2
NA

Day 3
7 tabs

Day 4
2 tabs

Day 5
6 tabs

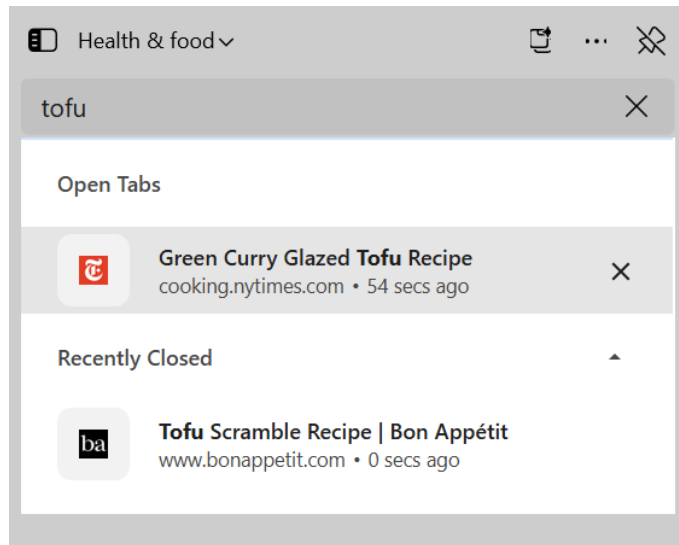
Day 6
5 tabs

"I used it mainly because I knew it was there"

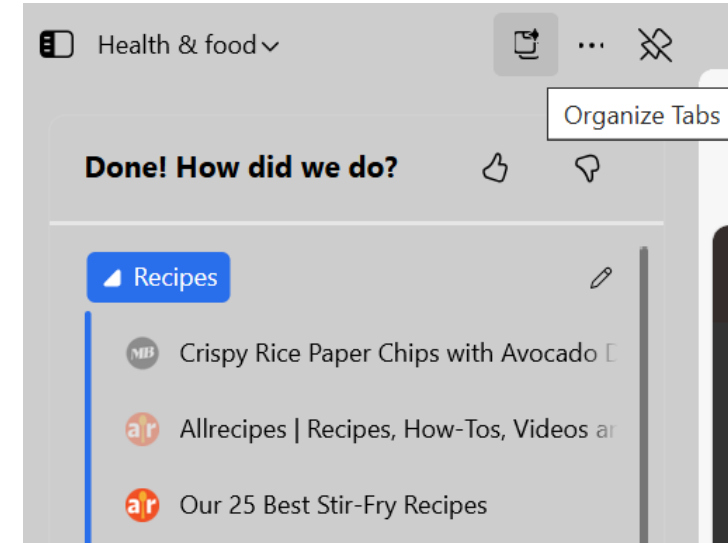
"I simply don't use tabs the way this was invented to"

Recommendation | When we define our users, tab volume plays a role, but so do attitudes towards managing (vs. closing off) open tabs.

Search and organize tabs can be selling points for users who want to stay in horizontal



Search tabs are best for recently closed or when there are many (15+) open tabs



Organize tabs can be useful but often inaccurate

Search and organize tabs can be selling points for users who want to stay in horizontal

Search tabs are best for recently closed or when there are many (15+) open tabs

5 only found recently closed useful, **4** only want it when there are many open tabs, **2** envisioned it as a robust key word search tool.

“I don't see the need in this feature so far for me with the way I use tabs. I guess if I had 15+ tabs open, I would... I still feel like I would be forcing it a little.” -Brandon

Organize tabs can be useful but often inaccurate

4 liked the categories, **3** felt the grouping wasn't accurate, **3** didn't want tabs grouped.

“I think they've made tabs very functional and intuitive and have enhanced it with these categories” -Debbie

“To me this makes it harder to use because it's like an extra click.” -Lauren

Recommendations | Push tab search to users when there is a very high volume of open tabs. More research to improve organize tabs.

Our participants aren't considering using Workspaces and tab groups together

The features don't mesh well

6 participants noted how difficult it is to move tab groups into a new Workspace. Right now, our designs aren't making it easy to create a tab hierarchy.

Only **1** participant considered how they would use both

"If I have few tabs, tab groups... workspaces If I have 11 or 12 tabs (for example, for online jobs)... or if I'm pressed for time" -Naomi

Participants prefer tab groups

9 participants preferred tab groups to Workspaces, because they don't get buried in the browser (4), because they are easier to maneuver (2), because they are lightweight (2), because they are familiar (1).

"Workspaces and tab groups accomplish similar purposes for me, and I would rather use tab groups in one workspace/window rather than having many different workspaces." -Hanson

Next Steps

Test Switcher mode in live to ensure that it



helps users manage tab clutter,



discover other tools,



explore vertical tabs,



with a salient escape hatch,



Push tab search to participants when there is a very high volume of open tabs, create more affordance for using tab groups and Workspaces together.

Thank you!

Profile | Shalon, PhD Applicant



Reserving one screen for horizontal and one screen for vertical tabs

Flipping between tabs is easier with horizontal

Shalon is actively researching the protohistory of various regions. He finds that it's quicker to flip between horizontal tabs than navigate vertical tabs in hover mode (it takes time to hover over each tab).

Delights

The organize tabs feature feels “pretty solid” to Shalon, though it takes a few tries to get right, and it labelled protohistory as prehistory.

Desires

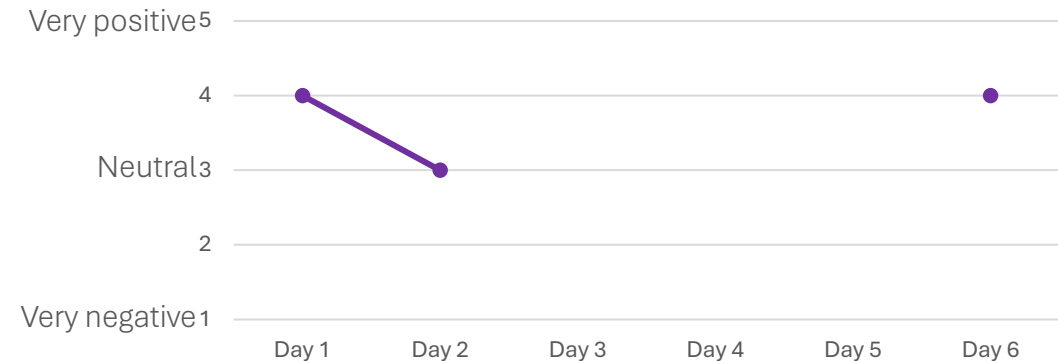
“I wish there was a way to make moving from the task in the center of my screen to the left side of my screen less time consuming with each individual action.”

How he used Tab Central

Kept it closed until he needed it

- Explored pinned & collapsed modes
- Organized tabs

Impressions



Why Switcher

He has no use for the dropdown menu, which isn't too appealing & feels unintuitive.

Profile | Debbie, Chief Information Officer



Organizing everyday tabs into groups

Debbie created a tab groups to organize shopping tabs, email inboxes, and work tabs.

Delights

Tab search for open and recently closed tabs, organize tabs

“The way to get to Feature X does not really stand out... I haven't found anything not working but I am not sure that it is good enough to change my browsing habits at this point.”

Pain Points

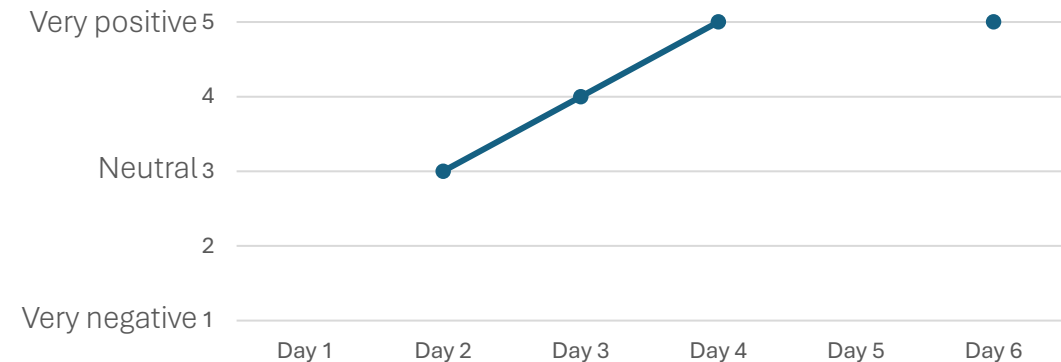
“The only thing I would add at this point is once I organize tabs that I could close the group with one click.”

How she used Tab Central

Explored pinning Tab Central, prefers unpinned

- Used tab grouping
- Used tab search
- Used Recently Closed

Impressions



Why Transient

Prefers to work with a dropdown menu because she has more space on her screen

Profile | Allison, College Student



Transient Condition
preferring Transient

Navigating coursework

On Day 2 Allison became overwhelmed with the number of tab she had in groups and couldn't find a specific tab she was looking for. She used Tab Central and Tab Search to locate the tab.

Delights

Tab search, closing tabs from the Tab Central menu, the hover preview in tab groups

Pain points

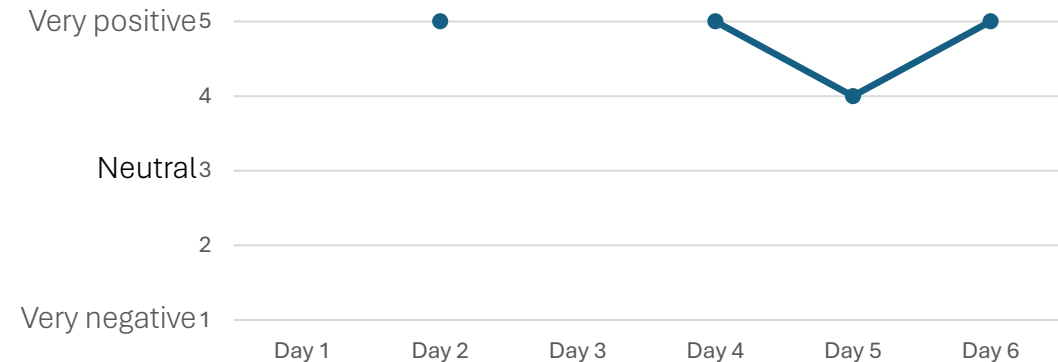
Organize tabs can be sort of general (i.e., broad categories).

How she used Tab Central

Didn't pin the Transient menu

- Used organize tabs
- Used tab search

Impressions



Why transient

Vertical tabs take up too much space, hover mode hides labels worse than even horizontal tabs.

Profile | Hanson, Masters Student



Switcher Condition
preferring Transient

Not a vertical tabs convert

Accustomed to horizontal tabs but enjoys being able to quickly close out tabs using Tab Central.

Delights

Enjoys search tabs, being able to skim the tabs he has open, enjoys the tab grouping features.

Wouldn't go looking for these tools

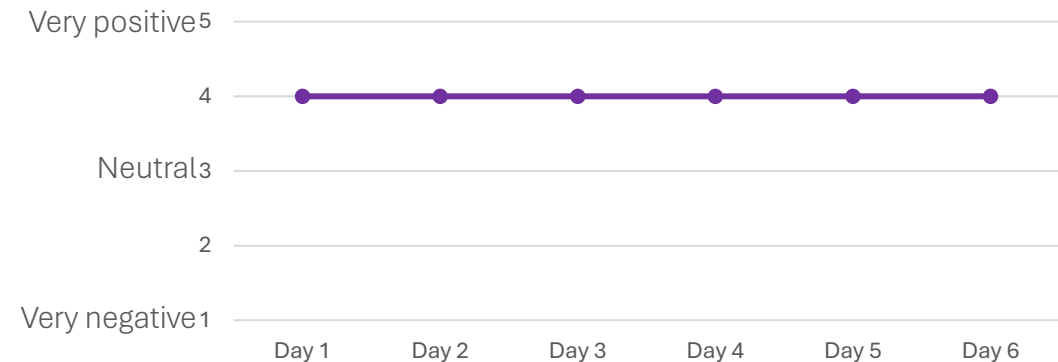
"If I wasn't in the study, I don't think I would have used Feature X today. I wouldn't have been exploring the Workspaces feature, and I don't have enough tabs open today where the advantages of the vertical look."

How he used Tab Central

Didn't use it unless he had active research tabs open.

- Explored pinned & collapsed modes
- Didn't discover that you could put the feature into hover mode

Impressions



Why Transient

All the benefits of Switcher mode but presenting them in a less in-your-face fashion.

Profile | Tyvon, Content Creator



Finding a specific Reddit tab

Tyvon used Tab Central to find specific tabs when he had multiple Reddit or YouTube pages open.

Delights

Tab search, organize tabs to create groups.

"I usually just remember where my tabs are and go from there....My method serves me well, but being able to search for tabs when you have 15-20 open saves a lot of time."

Pain Points

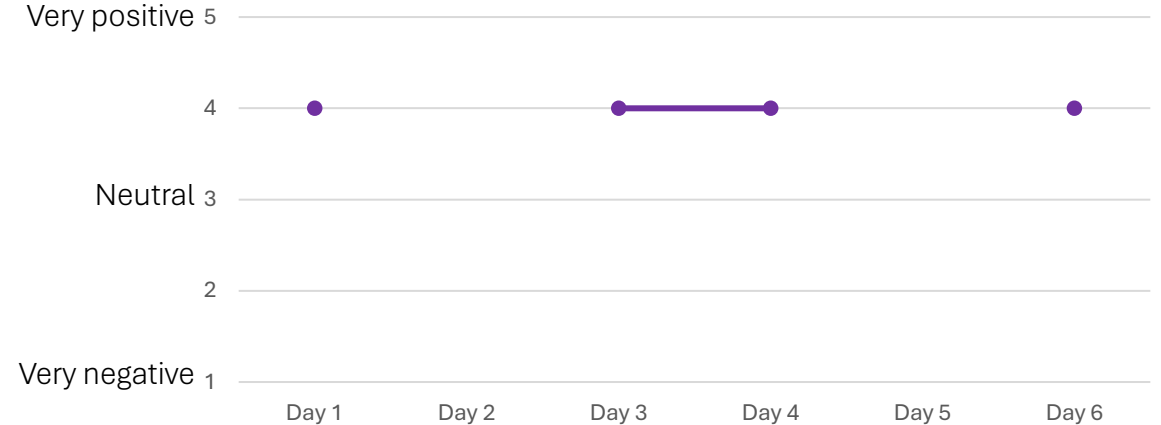
Sometimes Organize Tabs puts tabs into the wrong groups

How he used Tab Central

Left Tab Central open all the time

- Explored pinned & collapsed modes
- Played around with organize tabs on separate occasions, once with 30+ tabs

Impressions



Profile | Brandon, Field Engineer



Transient Condition
Preferring neither Switcher nor Transient

Right now he doesn't use tabs this way

"I think I'm getting more used to the features, but I just don't think it's for me the way that I use my browser... It's possible that I would instinctively not close as many tabs over time if I knew I had this feature, but I still feel like I would be forcing it a little".

Pain points

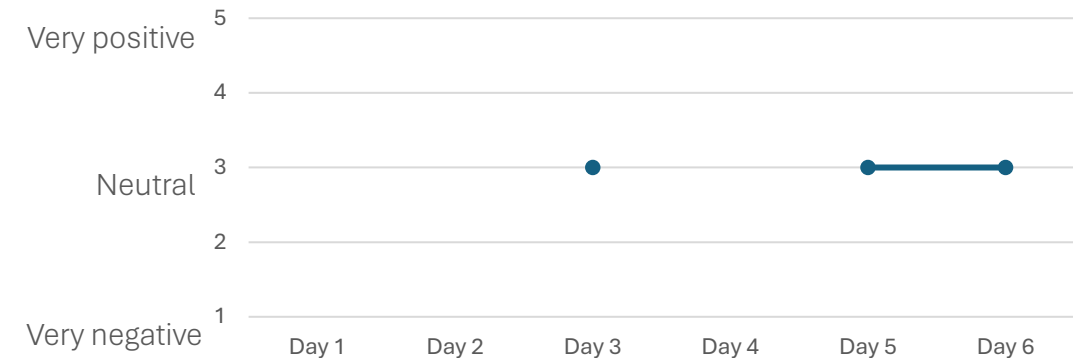
Can't think of a time when he would have enough tabs to need tab search, Workspaces fragments his browser.

How he used Tab Central

Didn't pin the Transient menu

- Experimented with analyzing his plans (PDFs) in browser windows, but would typically download them

Impressions



If he had to choose, it would be Switcher

He can't see himself using either, but Switcher feels more streamlined and sophisticated than Transient.

A few participants' detailed journey through the week

Days they didn't use the feature



College Student
Transient Condition

Day 1 3 tabs <i>"I already use tab grouping and having multiple windows open... and that served its purpose of organizing my work for today."</i>	Day 2 10 tabs - Organized tabs for a lab project - Closed off tabs using Feature X	Day 3 4 tabs 	Day 4 3 tabs <i>"I used my laptop today to keep track of some bills and watch some videos, which didn't require a lot of tabs."</i>	Day 5 7 tabs Hovered over tab group names for a preview of what's inside	Day 6 7 tabs Filling out documents, sending emails at the same time with split screen, using the hover preview
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PhD Applicant
Switcher Condition

Day 1 6-8 tabs - Conducting research, finding vertical tabs cumbersome - Pinning takes up too much space	Day 2 10-15 tabs - Continues to find vertical tabs cumbersome - The feature isn't right for the kind of research he's doing	Day 3 11 tabs <i>"I work a 9hr shift today and also did things for Valentine's Day."</i>	Day 4 2-3 tabs <i>"mostly just looking at 2-3 tabs today for research. Due to this, I didn't have much need to switch tabs or open many tabs."</i>	Day 5 5 tabs <i>"I actually reduced the number of tabs I am using as I finished my research today and I also wasn't on my computer much today."</i>	Day 6 26 tabs Organized 15+ websites into one group with Organize Tabs, took 4 attempts to get it right
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What everybody was saying about Transient vs. Switcher

Chose Transient



"[Pinned] wasn't my favorite mode because it takes up a lot of real estate on this side."



"it presents the feature in a less in-your-face fashion. I like the dropdown menu and pinning functionality."



"Transient having a pop-up that appears when you click the icon is condensed, but very useful."

Chose Switcher



"I have no need for the dropdown menu in Transient. It doesn't feel intuitive."



"I think the Transient feature takes up too much screen space."



"[Switcher] means less clicks for the same results."

Chose Neither



"They seem exactly the same to be honest."



"I do not see vertical tabs being something that I explore any further."



"If anything Switcher is even worse."

Four participants didn't pick up on any difference.

Why we still recommend Switcher | Participants preferring Transient can escape to horizontal when they need to.